

Housing & Urban Life

44 words · Housing & Urban Life

NOUNS

landlord

a person who owns and rents out property to tenants

Our landlord finally fixed the leaking roof after three phone calls.

deposit

a sum of money paid in advance as a guarantee, usually returned if the property is left undamaged

The landlord asked for a deposit equal to one month's rent.

neighbourhood

a district or area within a town or city, especially in relation to the people who live there

It's a quiet neighbourhood, mostly families and older couples.

outskirts

the outer parts of a town or city, away from the centre

The new shopping centre was built right on the outskirts.

urbanisation

the process by which more and more people come to live in cities rather than the countryside

Rapid urbanisation over the last two decades has pushed housing prices far beyond what most locals can afford.

eyesore

something very unattractive to look at, especially a building or structure

That grey car park is a real eyesore right next to such a beautiful old square.

gridlock

a situation in which traffic is so heavy that vehicles cannot move at all

By five o'clock most weekdays, the whole city centre is in complete gridlock and buses barely move.

tenant

a person who pays rent to use a property that belongs to someone else

The new tenants moved in at the start of the month.

flatmate

a person you share a rented flat with

I met my current flatmate through a friend of a friend.

suburb

a residential area on the edge of a city or large town

They swapped their city-centre flat for a house in the suburbs.

landmark

a building or feature that is easily recognised and often used to help people find their way

Just head towards the old clock tower: it's the main landmark in town.

gentrification

the process by which a poorer area becomes more fashionable and expensive as wealthier residents and businesses move in

Gentrification has turned the old warehouse district into rows of boutiques and expensive flats.

amenities

useful or desirable facilities and services available in a place, such as shops, schools or transport links

The listing boasted about local amenities, but the nearest shop was a twenty-minute walk away.

metropolis

a very large, busy city, especially the main city of a country or region

Twenty years ago it was a quiet port town; today it's a booming metropolis of two million people.

footfall

the number of people who visit or pass through a particular place, such as a shop or public area

Pedestrianising the high street boosted footfall by nearly a third.

ADJECTIVES

spacious

having plenty of room

The bedrooms are small, but the kitchen is really spacious.

pricey

costing more than expected or wanted (informal)

The flats by the river are gorgeous but a bit pricey for us.

liveable

pleasant, practical and comfortable to live in

Adding more parks and cycle lanes has made the city centre far more liveable.

cosmopolitan

having a mix of people and influences from many different countries and cultures

It's an incredibly cosmopolitan city: you can hear half a dozen languages on any given street corner.

cramped

uncomfortably small, with too little space

Five of us lived in a cramped two-bedroom flat during university.

dilapidated

old and in a poor, neglected condition

The old cinema on the corner has stood dilapidated and boarded up for a decade.

sleepy

(of a place) quiet, calm and without much activity

It was a sleepy little town until the new motorway brought everyone through it.

teeming

full of people or things moving around in large numbers

By mid-morning the old town was teeming with tourists and market stalls.

VERBS

rent

to pay someone regularly for the use of their property

We've been renting the same flat for four years now.

haggle

to negotiate over the price of something, trying to get it lower

Worth trying to haggle a little. The flat's been empty for two months.

pedestrianise

to convert a street or area for pedestrians only, banning cars and other vehicles

The council pedestrianised the market square, and cafés now spill out onto the cobbles.

PHRASAL VERBS

move in

to start living in a new home

We're moving in next Saturday, so expect boxes everywhere.

move out

to leave a home for good, taking your belongings with you

He's still living with his parents at thirty but planning to move out this year.

fork out

to pay for something, often reluctantly or a larger amount than expected

We had to fork out for a new boiler within our first month there.

grow on someone

to gradually become more likeable to someone over time

It's grown on me so much over the years, I can't picture living anywhere else.

price out

to make something so expensive that someone is unable to buy it or take part in it

Local families are being priced out of the neighbourhood they grew up in.

COLLOCATIONS

within walking distance

close enough to reach on foot without needing transport

The flat is within walking distance of the station, which sold it for us.

beyond recognition

changed so completely that the original state can no longer be seen

The old harbour's changed beyond recognition.

urban sprawl

the uncontrolled spread of a city's buildings and suburbs into the surrounding countryside

Urban sprawl has swallowed up farmland for miles in every direction.

IDIOMS

just around the corner

very close by

Easy, it's just around the corner: turn left past the old post office.

get on the property ladder

to buy your first property, seen as the first step towards owning more valuable homes later

Without help from her parents, she'd never have got on the property ladder this young.

hustle and bustle

busy, noisy activity and movement, typically associated with cities

After a week in the mountains, I actually missed the hustle and bustle of the city.

a melting pot

a place where a mixture of different peoples, cultures or ideas exist and blend together

The port district has always been a melting pot, shaped by generations of new arrivals.

a roof over your head

basic shelter or accommodation

After months of sleeping on friends' sofas, all he wanted was a roof over his head again.

SET PHRASES

it's just around the corner

used to tell someone that a place is very close by

The pharmacy you're after? It's just around the corner, past the bakery.

I'll take it

said to confirm you want to rent or buy a property you've just viewed

Honestly? I loved it. I'll take it.

location, location, location

a saying used to stress that where a property is situated matters more than anything else about it

It's small and needs work, but as the agent kept reminding us: location, location, location.

MODERN SLANG

gaff

a house or flat, someone's home (British informal)

Nice gaff! How long have you lived here?

digs

(British informal) lodgings; a rented room or flat, especially for a student

I spent my first year at university in some pretty grim digs above a chip shop.